

Abhandlung zur Rezeptionsforschung

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Trailing Nietzsche: Gershom Scholem and the Sabbatean Dialectics

Abstract: Gershom Scholem, the most predominant scholar of Jewish Mysticism in our times, is highly known for his contribution to the field of Jewish history. But his intellectual origins lay in his adolescence, and in his heretical-philosophical criticism of the Judeo-Christian morality and the ideology of the German bourgeoisie. These early impressions and thoughts appeared in one of his first Hebrew articles, “Redemption Through Sin”, published in Palestine in 1937. Scholem’s discussion analyzed the “nihilistic revolution” of the Sabbataeans and Frankists in the seventeenth and eighteenth century in Europe, whose main feature was the rejection of the normative ethics of rabbinic Judaism. The hidden core of the young Scholem, his revolutionary thought, was followed by an early encounter with the writings of Friedrich Nietzsche. The dream of young Scholem, as revealed by his diary, to write “Zarathustra for the Jews”, eventually came into being in an original adaptation. His great book *Sabbatai Sevi* (1957), can be read as a Nietzschean re-reading of “Redemption Through Sin”. The biography of Sabbatai Sevi as a Jewish Zarathustra may provide refreshing insights into the development of Scholem’s thought and an opportunity to challenge him through an analogical perspective.

Keywords: Gershom Scholem, Nihilism, Religion, Messianism, Sabbateanism.

Zusammenfassung: Gershom Scholem, der maßgebliche Gelehrte unserer Zeit in Sachen jüdischer Mystizismus, ist bestens bekannt auch für seinen Beitrag auf dem Feld der jüdischen Geschichte. Aber seine intellektuellen Ursprünge lagen in seiner Jugend und seiner damaligen häretisch-philosophischen Kritik der jüdisch-christlichen Moralität und der Ideologie der deutschen Bourgeoisie. Diese frühen Eindrücke und Gedanken erschienen in einem seiner ersten hebräischen Artikel, *Erlösung durch Sünde*, veröffentlicht in Palästina 1937. Scholem nahm sich in seiner Analyse die „nihilistische Revolution“ der Sabbatäer und Frankisten im 17. und 18. Jahrhundert in Europa vor, deren Grundhaltung die Ablehnung der normativen Ethik des rabbinischen Judentums war. Das ihm selbst noch verborgene revolutionäre Denken des jungen Scholem stieß in der Folge auf die Schriften Friedrich Nietzsches. Der Traum des jungen Scholem, einen „Zarathustra für die Juden“ zu schreiben, kam schließlich in einer originellen Adaptation zutage. Sein großes Buch *Sabbatai Zwi* (1957) kann als neue nietzscheanische Lektüre von *Erlösung durch Sünde* gelesen werden. Die Biographie von Sabbatai Zwi als jüdischem Zarathustra könnte zu anregend neuen Einsichten in die Entwicklung von Scholems Denken führen und zugleich die Gelegenheit geben, ihn durch eine analoge Perspektive herauszufordern.

Schlagwörter: Gershom Scholem, Nihilismus, Religion, Messianismus, Sabbatianismus.

*And what's so wonderful about Zarathustra? [...]
 Zarathustra is in fact a new Bible [...].
 To write something like it is my ideal.
 Gershom Scholem*

The Jewish Zarathustra?

On the 23rd of July 1918, Gershom Scholem, who was then a Berlin student making his first steps in wrestling with his Jewish identity, wrote in his diary: “Sometimes I start to think that Friedrich Nietzsche is the only one in modern times who has said anything substantial about ethics.”¹ This “substantial thing” which the author of *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* introduced into the sphere of morality was of course the Nietzschean revolution of the shift from ethics to aesthetics, the transvaluation of values, and the new criteria of the will to power and decadence which are beyond good and evil. These heretical philosophical views concerning the Judeo-Christian morality and the ideology of the German bourgeoisie (the young Scholem rebelled against his father, who represented the liberal lifestyle and bourgeois mentality of the assimilated Jew) left their imprint on the Jewish thinker at the beginning of his scholarly career. And indeed, his first major Hebrew article, “Mitzva ha-baa be-avera” (“Redemption Through Sin”), published in Palestine in 1937, discussed what was described as the “nihilistic revolution” of the Sabbataeans and Frankists in the seventeenth and eighteenth century in Europe, whose main feature was the rejection of the normative ethics of rabbinic Judaism.²

Alexander Kraushaar, the author of the book *Frank: Frankiści Polsky, 1726–1816* (1895), compared *Divrei ha-adon* (Words of the Lord), a hagiography of Jacob Frank written by his followers and considered the “credo” of the Frankist unbelievers, to Nietzsche’s *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*:

When we examined the content of these strange little entries, we were reminded of the new German philosopher Nietzsche and his famous book *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, for they too are written beautifully and strangely and with brevity, and if we can find our way among the meanderings of the spiritual paths represented in these chapters, we will be able to form a mental picture of all that Frank did [...].³

1 Gershom Scholem, *Tagebücher 1913–1923*, Bd. I-II, unter Mitarbeit von Herbert Knopp-Oberstebrink hg. v. Karlfried Gründer und Friedrich Niewöhner, Frankfurt am Main 1995–2000. The two German volumes were translated into English and appeared in a single volume in a slightly abridged form twelve years later at Harvard, from which I cite: Gershom Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth – The Diaries of Gershom Scholem, 1913–1919*, ed. and trans. by Anthony David Skinner, Cambridge, Mass. 2007, p. 253.

2 The expression “the nihilist revolution,” appeared in Gerschom Scholem, *The Sabbatian Movement in Poland*, in: *Studies and Texts Concerning the History of Sabbataianism and Its Metamorphoses*, Jerusalem 1974, p. 128. The “nihilist revolution” is also the main subject of “Redemption Through Sin”, in: Gerschom Scholem, *The Messianic Idea in Judaism and Other Essays on Jewish Spirituality* [1937], New York 1971, pp. 78–141. See David Ohana, *The Origins of Israeli Mythology*, New York / Cambridge 2012; David Ohana, *Zarathustra in Jerusalem: Friedrich Nietzsche and Jewish Modernity*, Jerusalem 2016 [Hebrew].

3 Alexander Kraushaar, *Frank: Frankiści Polsky, 1726–1816*, Vols. 1–2, Cracow 1895, p. 19.

The comparison made by the Polish historian between Jacob Frank and Friedrich Nietzsche is instructive both in itself and with regard to Scholem's affinity to Nietzsche and his dealings with Frank, two figures who sought to bring about a revolution in the sphere of morals. The parallel between Frank and Nietzsche demonstrates more than any number of witnesses the degree to which the influence of the philosopher of the "nihilistic revolution" affected the greatest scholar of Judaism in the twentieth century. Frank and Nietzsche consciously despised and rejected the moral norms of bourgeois culture and called for a reversal and transvaluation of values. This call was heeded by an isolated sect of eighteenth-century Jewry on the one hand and major intellectual currents at the beginning of the twentieth century on the other, penetrated deeply and was dialectically expressed in various forms of heresy, secularism, radicalism, and revolutionism. These long drawn-out processes shook things to the core, changed the existing intellectual climate and accelerated the modernizing sociological tendencies of various strata both among the Jews in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries and among philosophers, ideologists, political activists, theologians and educationalists in Europe. It is interesting to note in this connection that one of Scholem's first articles in Hebrew and the most important was devoted to a discussion of the Frankist and Sabbataian phenomenon and the revolution of consciousness that took place in enlightened circles of European Jewry, circles that sought an explanation for the heretical religiosity of Frank and his sect and also for their own heretical religiosity.⁴ In Scholem's opinion, this theological antinomianism led to a reflective self-consciousness among major Jewish figures, to currents of enlightenment and to a European and Zionist revolutionism.

Scholem himself, when he was seventeen years old, wrote in his diary on the 17th of November 1914: "And what's so wonderful about Zarathustra? [...] Zarathustra is in fact a new Bible, regardless of what one thinks about the ideas it propounds. To write something like it is my ideal."⁵ It is therefore not surprising if the editor of the English edition of Scholem's diaries called the preface he wrote "A Zarathustra for the Jews".⁶ Other Scholem scholars followed suit and connected together the Jewish thinker, the German philosopher and the work with the name of the Persian god. The dream of the young Scholem was not so far from the reality, and it may have taken on flesh and blood in his great book *Sabbatai Sevi* (1957), an exemplary work which is an aesthetic retelling of the Sabbataian revolt. But one may go further and say that the Nietzschean revolution against the Judeo-Christian morality was already exemplified as an aesthetic phenomenon in the article "Redemption Through Sin" written twenty years before the biography of the seventeenth-century false Messiah. Consequently, a re-examination of the early article and the biography and reading them as "A Zarathustra for the Jews" is by no means unreasonable, and it may even provide refreshing insights into the development of Scholem's ideas and an opportunity to challenge him through an analogical perspective.⁷

In which way did the Nietzschean influence affect the young Scholem, or the older one, for that matter? Was it a youthful phase, a need for a ladder (in the same way as Micha Yosef

4 Rachel Elior, Jacob Frank and His Book *The Sayings of the Lord*: Religious Anarchism as a Restoration of Myth and Metaphor, in: Rachel Elior (ed.), *The Sabbatian Movement and Its Aftermath: Messianism, Sabbatianism and Frankism*, vol. II, Jerusalem 2001, pp. 471–548 [Hebrew].

5 Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, p. 36.

6 Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, p. 9.

7 Cf. David Ohana, *The Myth of Zarathustra: Martin Buber, Gershom Scholem and the Nationalisation of Jewish Myth*, in: David Ohana, *Modernism and Zionism*, New York 2002, pp. 29–79.

Berdichevsky, Franz Rosenzweig, Martin Buber and Hillel Zeitlin needed one, for instance), a necessary stairway in the process of self-construction (*Bildung*), or was it a case of an inner affinity with matters which Scholem was concerned with all his life, such as nihilism, self-overcoming, normative morality and the will to power? These matters preoccupied the young Scholem and gave him the spiritual strength to do great things, to be a “superman” laying with his own hands his life’s path and urging him to be a Messiah to his people. Scholem aspired to a life of greatness and creativity, and intended to write his masterpiece, or another great work, or both, which would give him his place among other great modern thinkers like himself.

Scholem’s Zionism is shown here to be existentialist rather than political. It demands of the Jews, as of himself, self-overcoming and the transvaluation of the bourgeois values of exilic Judaism. His model is Zarathustra; his anarchic call for a “revolution everywhere” also applies to his own camp. Zionism must break open the boundaries of exile. His approach was a Jewish interpretation of the European crisis, and the radical answer to it was Zion, which represented “the equilibrium of all things”, “the solution to all incompleteness.” For him, Zionism was “the need for a splendid life in Palestine.” Benjamin Lazier has suggested that the change of names from Gerhardt to Gershom and from Scholem to Shalom was an example of the Nietzschean principle of self-overcoming and of the conscious creation of the “self.”⁸ Out of all the works one can think of, Scholem chose Nietzsche’s early essays, *Untimely Meditations* (not the works generally considered most important), as ideal models of praise of the Bible – a clear sign of Scholem’s respectful attitude to Nietzsche.

At the beginning of Scholem’s career as a historian, when he was making his first steps as a researcher of Kabbala, conservative approaches were common in Germany, as were nationalist outlooks in German universities.⁹ History was the jewel in the crown of the national myth, and Treitschke was its spokesman. Just as he rejected the possibility of the universality of mysticism, Scholem rejected the possibility that his Jewish nationalism bore any resemblance to German nationalism. Scholem was disgusted at the patriotic euphoria of the Germans, including many Jews (for example Buber and Simmel), at the time of the First World War; he despised the bourgeois way of life and left his father’s home; he enthusiastically aligned himself with cultural Zionism and denied the possibility of a Jewish-German symbiosis. He did, however, acknowledge the philosophical heritage that the Jews received from the Germans, though not his debt to Nietzsche in Germany.¹⁰

The abundant examples of the affinity of the young Jewish scholar to the German philosopher sprang up in purely German soil. Later on, I shall consider whether these affinities were shifting or accidental. If that is so, Scholem’s later disavowal of Nietzsche and his insistence on stressing his alienation from the harmful influence of the author of *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* are most surprising. Here are two typical examples of Scholem’s reactions. In May 1975, he told the American-Jewish scholar of Hebrew literature Robert Alter about the fine review published in *Commentary* of the English translation of *Sabbatai Sevi*, but “to Nietzsche, I must confess that I feel no kinship to him or to his heritage, and as a young man

⁸ Benjamin Lazier, *Writing the Judenzarathustra: Gershom Scholem’s Response to Modernity, 1913–1917*, in: *New German Critique* 85 (Winter 2002), pp. 33–65; *God Interrupted – Heresy and the European Imagination Between The World Wars*, Princeton / Oxford 2008, p. 153.

⁹ Henry Pachter, *Masters of Cultural History. Gershom Scholem – The Myth of the Mythmaker*, in: *Salmagundi* 40 (Winter 1978), pp. 9–39.

¹⁰ Robert Alter, *The Achievement of Gershom Scholem*, in: *Commentary* 55 (April 1973), pp. 69–77.

I turned away in disgust from those writings of Nietzsche which came into my hands. Unfortunately, those seem to have been the wrong ones, like *Zarathustra*, and they prevented me from delving deeper.”¹¹

Again, in March 1978, Scholem reacted angrily to a critical article by Henry Pachter: “Gershom Scholem: the Myth of the Myth-Maker”. Scholem called it “a very strange essay full of the most nonsensical assertions about me,” and he explained: “what I found particularly amusing was the discovery that I derive from Nietzsche and that my work ‘obviously’ stands under the influence of *The Birth of Tragedy*, a work that I have never read, as I have hardly read Nietzsche at all, apart from *Zarathustra*, which particularly repelled me.”¹² Once in Palestine, Scholem abandoned his preoccupation with the Messianic aspect of the war and the revolution in Europe in favor of his researches into the Kabbala and involvement in the new problems that arose in the Middle East. In the first years of his immigration, there was a change in his understanding of the concepts “anarchism” and “nihilism”, and he gave them new meanings.¹³ In his late article “Nihilism as a Religious Phenomenon” (1974), the result of a lecture to the Eranos circle, he described nihilism differently from the way he had done previously: the nihilist was now seen as a revolutionary, “a sworn opponent to every kind of authority, who is unable to accept principles of belief if they are not linked to the basic intention of the principles.”¹⁴

Echoes of the aesthetic revolution created by Nietzsche reached the German-Jewish youth, Gerhardt Scholem, who, between chapters of the Bible and portions of the Talmud that he studied under the guidance of the orthodox rabbi Isaac Bleichrode, also hungrily devoured the works of Søren Kierkegaard, Arthur Schopenhauer, Hugo Hofmannsthal, Stefan George, and, needless to say, Nietzsche. In one of the early entries in his diary, in November 1914, Scholem identified aestheticism with Nietzsche:

Aestheticism! Oh this word, an abyss on whose opposite side is nothingness. Aestheticism, by which of course is meant self-conscious aestheticism, is the dying man’s last shivers and final attempt at life.¹⁵

Before Nietzsche, the aesthetic education of mankind envisaged by the Enlightenment and the Romantic movement had been closely connected with moral and rational improvement.¹⁶

¹¹ Gershom Scholem, *A Life in Letters, 1914–1982*, ed. and trans. David Shinner, Cambridge, Mass. 2001, p. 454.

¹² Gershom Scholem, *Briefe*, vol. 3, 1971–1972, ed. Itta Shedletzky, Munich 1999, p. 178.

¹³ Arthur Danto’s basic premise was that Nietzsche’s “nihilism [...] is not an ideology, but metaphysics.” Danto distinguished between Nietzsche’s “metaphysical” nihilism (“reality itself has neither name nor form”) and the “St. Petersburg style of nihilism”: that is a nihilism which rejects and destroys a whole series of religious, moral and political principles. Nietzsche’s nihilism was not a functional nihilism but an immanent nihilism. Metaphysical nihilism is confined to the here-and-now or to put it in Ofelia Schutte’s words: “Nietzsche would like to see the metaphysician rooted in the earth.” Its meaning is not the rejection of the significance of the universe, and not “eternal recurrence” as found in the Stoics and Ecclesiastes, but a horrified, yet courageous glance at a universe without a purpose.

¹⁴ Gershom Scholem, *Der Nihilismus als religiöses Phänomen*, in: *Eranos Jahrbuch* 43 (1974), pp. 1–40 [German].

¹⁵ Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, p. 42.

¹⁶ Josef Chytrý, *The Aesthetic State. A Quest in Modern German Thought*, Berkeley 1989.

Kant, in his *Critique of Judgement* (1790), expressed the view that aesthetic judgement of a universal character represented beauty as a moral good; Schiller, in his *Letters on the Aesthetic Education of Man* (1795), gave greater importance to aesthetic than to ethical appreciation, but as a pupil of Kant, he preferred speculative reason; Schelling, in his *System of Transcendental Idealism* (1800), taught that the supremely rational act was an aesthetic one in which truth and goodness were fused with beauty. Schelling claimed that mythology, reason and ethics were identical, so that intellectual observation could be regarded an aesthetic observation.¹⁷ Nietzsche, on the other hand, as I have mentioned, was the first thinker after the Enlightenment to sever any possible connection between morals and aesthetics. While Schelling saw art as the only sphere which reflected reality, Nietzsche regarded art as a total illusion which, therefore, unlike reason, was unable to make the false claim of depicting reality.

Scholem, for his part, declared that a natural people is in its essence an aesthetic entity, but that a decadent people loses its natural aestheticism, and “as a result – as with everything one lacks – it’s become a science, the science of aesthetics (or just look at the ‘Science of Judaism!’)”.¹⁸ Here one can discern a very early criticism by Scholem of *Jüdische Wissenschaft* (the Science of Judaism). “Sometimes it is tragic”, he writes, “when someone ardently desires life only to arrive at aesthetics. Hofmannsthal, Nietzsche, George. It’s a disaster, also called a *Kismet*. God save us from aesthetics! [...]”.¹⁹ As we know, the poet Stefan George at an early stage adopted Nietzsche as a philosopher-aesthetician who, as such, was able to bridge the gap between himself and Goethe.²⁰

A month later, Scholem once again attacked the scientific study of the Talmud and the Jewish proponents of methods imitative of the European method, which sterilize any “over-soul” in Judaism. These people, he said, wished to approach the Talmud “scientifically” but were incapable of studying it in the right way. Scholem saw himself and his contemporaries as a generation of the future which would change everything from top to bottom even if they hit their heads against a wall. This was a generation which aspired to see the Holy Land, the Promised Land in the full sense of the concept. “Where is our Moses?”, asked Scholem. The people in their exile needed a leader like Moses or Jesus: “his name just mustn’t be Hermann Cohen.”²¹ The youthful, optimistic, and challenging spirit to be found here is cogently expressed in the following declaration: “with Nietzsche we say that the child’s land is the land of the future.”²² Scholem was referring here to Nietzsche’s words in the section “On Old and New Tablets” of *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*:

O my brethren, not backward shall your nobility gaze, but outward! Exiles shall ye be from all fatherlands and forefather-lands! Your children’s land shall ye love: let this love be your new nobility, –the undiscovered in the remotest seas! For it do I bid your sails search and search! Unto your children shall ye make amends for being the children of your fathers: all the past shall ye thus redeem! This new table do I place over you!²³

17 Frederick C. Beiser, *The Fate of Reason: German Philosophy from Kant to Fichte*, Cambridge, Mass. 1987.

18 Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, p. 47.

19 Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, p. 47.

20 Steven E. Aschheim, *The Nietzsche Legacy in Germany*, Berkeley 1994, pp. 71–83.

21 Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, p. 43.

22 Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, p. 42.

23 Nietzsche, *Z III, On Old and New Tables*, transl. by Stanley Appelbaum, New York 1999, § 12.

At the beginning of 1915, Scholem began his diary with the announcement that the German novelist and writer on the philosophy of art Friedrich Theodor Vischer had made a very great impression on him. Vischer recorded that in his conversations with Schopenhauer, the latter had said that “a stupid devil, the so-called will, created the world.”²⁴ Scholem acknowledged that this insight gave him the understanding that “this inspired my speculation into the religiosity in German literature and elsewhere, including inside myself. It’s now obvious that I don’t believe in a personal God, even less in a being embodying the idea of morality! My God is but an ideal generated by dreams of a fulfilled human life.”²⁵ In the nineteenth century, Scholem went on, heaven was broken up until it vanished for ever. After the age of romanticism had still retained the old dreams, there were two major periods of change. The first period was represented by Schopenhauer, Marx and Max Stirner: “Schopenhauer was the one who murdered the absolute God. It’s just as Nietzsche said: God is utterly dead, even if his murderer limited himself to metaphysics.” After Schopenhauer came Marx’s turn to shatter the illusions of the transcendental heaven and Stirner’s turn to say *kaddish* over God: “After which a second generation – Strindberg, Nietzsche and Ibsen – came on the scene to rattle heaven with their romanticism. For the upper classes they created a lot more stir in the dubious region of heaven than the other three. Next came Søren Kierkegaard and Tolstoy, two giants who, no doubt, unwittingly destroyed heaven through their deep religiosity. We today have nothing left of the heaven of the past.”²⁶

It is extraordinary how perspicacious the young Scholem was in his diary about the illusions of the First World War and the European culture that brought it about. His conclusions anticipated those of Ernst Bloch and Walter Benjamin.²⁷ The war was a traumatic event for them; unlike many of their peers, they were revolted by it even before it began. They looked on with frustration as their spiritual mentors – Martin Buber for Benjamin and Georg Simmel for Bloch – greeted the war with the enthusiasm of the Nietzschean *Lebensphilosophie*. In fact, Benjamin refused to write for Buber’s paper *Der Jude*. Bloch’s greatest disappointment with what he called “the ideas of 1914” and “the utopias of the will” was Simmel’s support for the war. The diary shows Scholem’s negative attitude to the war, an attitude that exhibited intellectual ripening, political understanding and moral maturity – qualities that could not be ascribed to Buber or Simmel in this context.²⁸

His hostility to the war grew more and more intense. His meetings with his brother Werner, a communist, in Berlin, and the attempts of certain circles to stand against the violent storm threatening Europe, strengthened his resolve.²⁹ At the same time, as the leader of a small Zionist circle, “Young Judea”, he began to express his opposition to political

²⁴ Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, p. 47.

²⁵ Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, p. 47. For a new reading of Scholem, including a religious one, see: Daniel Weidner, *Reading Gershom Scholem*, in: *The Jewish Quarterly Review* 96.2 (Spring 2006), pp. 203–231.

²⁶ See especially Willi Goetschel, *Scholem’s Diaries, Letters, and New Literature on his Work*, in: *Germanic Review* 72 (1977), pp. 77–91.

²⁷ David Ohana, *Fascism as a Political Community of Experience: Following Walter Benjamin’s Political Phenomenology*, in: *Democratic Culture* 9 (2005), pp. 7–48 [Hebrew].

²⁸ Michael Brenner, *From Self-declared Messiah to Scholar of Messianism: the Recently Published Diaries of Young Gerhardt Scholem in a New Light*, in: *Jewish Social Studies* 3 (1996), p. 179.

²⁹ Gershom Scholem, *From Berlin to Jerusalem. Memories of My Youth*, trans. by Harry Zohn, Foreword by Moshe Idel, Philadelphia 2012, pp. 19, 30, 41–42, 71, 83–84, 144–45.

Zionism. In a letter of September 1914 to his brother Werner, Scholem said he was waiting for his medical examination for the army, in which he said he did not want to serve, and spoke of his relationship with his father, which had reached an impasse. Against this background, he expressed skepticism about the possibility of any laws in history and said he preferred an anarchistic philosophy:

Dear Werner, I do not believe in the philosophy of history – whether it be Hegel's (that is, Marx's), Ranke's, or Treitschke's, or (for all I care) even the negative form of it preached by Nietzsche. In other words, I believe that if history produces laws at all, either history or the laws are worthless. At the very most, I think that only anarchism can be of some use if you really want to prove something through history [...].³⁰

And, indeed, Nietzsche was the sworn enemy of historicism. Nietzsche's historical perspectivism was formed by Jacob Burckhardt's lectures which he heard in Bale in 1870, and by his opposition to the objectivity claimed by Hegel, as a philosopher of history, and by Leopold von Ranke as a historian.³¹ Nietzsche brought a breath of fresh air into the historiographical climate of opinion, which began with a religious belief in the operation of the divine intelligence and ended with the secular challenge of gaining an objective knowledge of history through scientific methods (i. e., historicism).

As against the scientific historiographical pretensions of the school of Ranke, the young Scholem was convinced for a while that he was destined to be the Messiah. Buber, his Zionist hero and the hero of his generation of Jews, was cast in the role of prophet, like Nathan of Gaza:

He only wanted to prepare the way for someone greater than he who was to come. He sacrificed himself for the others, for those he did not know but whose blood he shares. He was not the redeemer.

[...] Beyond searching and the crying out, fulfillment also stirred in him. At first he didn't recognize this fulfillment, nor did he yet know its object [...].

This young man went alone through the world and looked around to find where the soul of the nation awaited him. He believed deeply that the soul of Judea wandered aimlessly among the nations and in the Holy Land, awaiting the One who would have enough audacity to free it from banishment and from the separation from its national body. Deep down inside he knew that he was the Chosen One who was to search for his people's soul, and to find it; that he must equip himself to pave the way for the soul's discovery. [...]. The simple man's way is the path of redemption. And who is this dreamer, whose name already marks him as the Awaited One? It is Scholem, the Perfect One. It was he who equipped himself for his work and began to powerfully forge together weapons of knowledge.³²

A few months later, Scholem changed his mind, and declared: "At this moment I no longer believe as I once did that I'm the Messiah."³³ The historian Michael Brenner said that

³⁰ Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, p. 26.

³¹ Solomon Liptzin (ed.), *From Novalis to Nietzsche: Anthology of Nineteenth Century German Literature*, New York 1929.

³² Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, p. 57 (22nd May 1915).

³³ Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, p. 68 (19th September 1915).

Scholem met Buber about five months after he wrote this, and readers of the diary cannot help raising an ironic smile at the thought of the relationship that must have existed between the would-be Messiah and his designated prophet.³⁴ It is clear that contrary to the criticisms leveled by some Kabbala scholars, Scholem was by no means a stranger to subjects that he wrote about such as mysticism and Messianism.³⁵ Casting oneself as the Messiah was nothing unusual at that time: we know of Theodor Herzl's Messianic vision and the Messianic secular-universalist outlook of David Ben-Gurion.

The Herzl legend is enveloped in a Messianic halo. Herzl internalized it to such a degree that he made a comparison between himself and Shabbetai Zevi: "The difference between me and Shabbetai Zevi as I imagine him, apart from developments in technical resources due to the difference in periods, is that Shabbetai Zevi raised himself up to resemble the great ones of the earth, while I find the great ones of the earth to be as small as I am."³⁶ Dr. Joseph Bloch warned him against the temptation of presenting himself as a Messiah, as all the Messiahs "had brought disastrous consequences upon the Jews." He said that as soon as a Messiah "puts on flesh and blood, he ceases to be a redeemer."³⁷ Herzl, however, did not trip up and did not cross the Shabbetaian threshold. When King Victor Emmanuel the Third told Herzl, when they met in 1904, that one of his distant relatives had been connected with Shabbetai Zevi, and he asked if there were still any Jews expecting the Messiah, Herzl replied, "Naturally, Your Majesty, in the religious circles. In our own, the academically trained and enlightened circles, no such thought exists, of course [...]. Our movement is purely nationalist." Herzl added that on his journey to Palestine he refrained from riding on a donkey "so that no one would embarrass me by thinking I was the Messiah."³⁸

When Ben-Gurion was ten years old, in 1896, the year of the publication of Herzl's *The Jewish State*, as he accompanied his father to pray in the synagogue, he heard that "it was being said in the town that the Messiah was on his way, and he was now in Vienna, and he had a black beard and his name was Herzl."³⁹ It was said that he was "tall and handsome and had a black beard – an extraordinary man."⁴⁰ Ben-Gurion looked at his picture and decided "to follow him immediately to the land of my fathers." And the founder of the Jewish State wrote about the prophet of the Jewish State: "Herzl was indeed like a Messiah since he galvanized the feeling of the youth that Eretz-Israel was achievable. He added, however, that it could only come to pass if we built it with our own hands."⁴¹

The young Ben-Gurion's recognition that doing it "with our own hands" was the sole condition for realizing Herzl's secular Messianism was central in molding his political and intellectual path. In his mythification of Herzl, Ben-Gurion contrasts exile, which is "slavery" and the "darkness of the cemetery," with Herzlian Zionism which epitomizes freedom,

³⁴ Brenner, *From Self-declared Messiah*, p. 179.

³⁵ Steven E. Aschheim, *The Metaphysical Psychologist: On the Life and Letters of Gershom Scholem*, in: *The Journal of Modern History* 76 (December 2004), p. 913.

³⁶ Robert Wistrich, *Herzl Following the Messiah*, in: David Ariel-Yoel et al. (eds.), *The War of Gog and Magog: Messianism and Apocalypse in Judaism – In the Past and Present*, Tel Aviv 2001, pp. 125–41 [Hebrew].

³⁷ Charles Bloch, *Theodor Herzl and Joseph S. Bloch*, in: *Herzl Year Book* 1 (1958), pp. 158–64.

³⁸ Theodor Herzl, *Diaries*, Vol. 3, Jerusalem 2001, p. 256. [Hebrew].

³⁹ David Ben-Gurion, *Memories*, I, Tel-Aviv 1971, p. 7 [Hebrew].

⁴⁰ David Ben-Gurion, *My Father's House*, Tel Aviv 1974, p. 16 [Hebrew].

⁴¹ David Ben-Gurion, *Recollections*, London 1970, p. 34.

light and resurrection. In another place he describes the exile as “a miserable experience, wretched, bitter, contemptible, nothing to be proud of. On the contrary – it has to be totally rejected.”⁴² Ben Gurion’s negation of the exile was to influence his ideas of “shortening the path” of history and breaking the continuity of Jewish history.⁴³

These two statesmen worked in their mature years to realize Zionism, their early Messianic vision,⁴⁴ and the young self-appointed Messiah became the doyen of historians of Jewish Messianism. In a confession striking in its honesty, Scholem declared: “I can never provide a narrative in which I do not play the leading role.” Thus, we see that in his attack on political Zionism he was really aiming at Herzl, the head of the pyramid. The intellectual atmosphere in which he lived explains his revulsion at politics, his attachment to the cultural sphere and his attraction to the anarchic. Scholem wanted to be the ultimate revolutionary, a Zionist revolutionary:

Our guiding principle is revolution! Revolution everywhere! We don’t want reform or reeducation but revolution or renewal. We desire to absorb revolution into our innermost souls. There are external and internal revolutions [...]. We should be revolutionaries and always and everywhere say who we are, what we are, and what we want. For the sake of Judah we want to fight it out with our foes. Above all, we want to revolutionize Judaism. We want to revolutionize Zionism and to preach anarchism and freedom from all authority. We will go to battle against all autocrats [...]. We wish to rip away the formalistic facade from Zionism. In doing so we’ve arrived at Herzl, but only taking from him the force of his personality. We reject him. He’s *to blame* for today’s Zionism – a movement that instead of going forward looks backwards, an organization of shopkeepers that grovels in the dust before the powerful! Zionism is *Mauschel!!* It has taken up the Jewish problem merely as a form instead of in its inner essence. Its only thought has been the Jewish *state*. We preachers of anarchism reject this. We don’t want a state. We want a free society, and Herzl’s *Old-New Land* hasn’t a thing to do with this! We Jews are not a people of the state, go to Palestine to found a state, thereby forging new chains out of the old [...]. We want to go to Palestine out of a thirst for freedom and longing for the future. The future belongs to the Orient [...].⁴⁵

Scholem’s Zionist revolution was one that worked through changing hearts and not through political action, through Judaism and not through diplomacy, through a culture and not through a State. The expression he used, “the idol of the state”, was taken from the chapter on the new idol in *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*: “Somewhere there are still peoples and herds, but not where we live, my brothers: here there are states [...]. State is the name of the coldest of all monsters.” Nietzsche added: “The gentlest words are those that bring on the storm.” (Z I, On the New Idol) Nearby Scholem also quoted the words of Buber, who pointed out that the decisions are not made in a proud spirit but in a state of humility. Scholem concluded that great events take place far from the noise of the storm, in the depths of things and not externally. “Remarkably enough,” added Scholem, “Nietzsche apparently didn’t know Kierkegaard,

⁴² David Ben-Gurion, Davar, 9 October 1957 [Hebrew].

⁴³ Anita Shapira, Whatever Happened to the Negation of the Diaspora?, in: *Alpayim* 25 (2003), pp. 9–54 [Hebrew].

⁴⁴ David Ohana, The Myth of Prometheus: Zionism and the Modernization of Messianism, in: Ohana, *Modernism and Zionism*, pp. 80–122; David Ohana, *Political Theologies in the Holy Land: Israeli Messianism and its Critics*, London 2010, pp. 1–53.

⁴⁵ Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, pp. 48–49.

not even the monograph by Brandes.”⁴⁶ Scholem, referring to the correspondence between Nietzsche and his Jewish penfriend, Georg Brandes, continued: “But listen to what’s written in ‘Of a Thousand and One Aims’: First nations were creative, and only later were individuals. *Truly, the individual himself is the most recent creation.*”⁴⁷ After citing *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, Scholem added, “Isn’t this astounding?”

On the 15th of November, 1915, the first anniversary of his diary, Scholem wrote that he would stop keeping the diary as he was about to be called up. About a week later, he made a surprising announcement:

[...] We are Jews, which is a statement that must be properly understood. That we are also humans shall be called out with a full voice because some (or many) of my friends have forgotten it. It is no proof of one’s Zionism to think that being Jewish is to occupy oneself *only* with Jewish matters. Someone can be Jewish and be with Jean Paul, Gottfried Keller, and Friedrich Nietzsche. You can’t crawl out of your own skin, and for a Jew who knows something about his Judaism, there is nothing non-Jewish that can do damage to him if it’s not damaging to other people. It’s nonsense to assume that pursuing something else could lead you away from Zionism. Zionism is the presupposition for this pursuit. [...]. This is a lesson I’ve experienced and have understood over the past year.⁴⁸

Scholem’s self-respect as a Jew made him declare that there is no contradiction between being Jewish and being a human being, between being Jewish and being a follower of Nietzsche, between being a Zionist and being universal. As the son of an assimilated Jewish family, he went a long way – from nihilism to Zionism:

From nothingness I went to Orthodoxy, and from there I continued on to Buber; and from Buber – by *giving him up* – I arrived at Zion. [...]. Is the Bible’s divinity rooted in its humanity, as I once thought? No. Its divinity goes far, far deeper. It is *not* in myth, but in its view of history [...] Judaism is the *absolute* truth, it follows that the Bible and the Torah are divine. For this reason, one can employ the Bible as a proof. [...]. At the very core of Judaism lies the belief that there is a revelation from God, and this is something no modern man can grasp. This is the point that Kierkegaard never understood, which comes out clearly in his brand of Christianity. [...] Like Plato, he was Oriental, which is surely part of the problem with him, as it was with Nietzsche. For he approached philosophy from the question of history. [...] He too tried to overcome historical skepticism by going to its source. There [is] absolutely nothing more devastating than the scientific study of the Bible. [...] The Bible is the eternal *Untimely Meditations*. The Messiah will come during the generation in which the Bible is also “externally” relevant.⁴⁹

These sections of the diary were written in October 1916. At the height of the war they bear witness to Scholem’s consolidated Zionist outlook. Judaism, Bible and Zion are the ultimate answer to the nihilist escape that lies at the heart of the European crisis. Modernism is unable to explain the divine revelation; the philosophy of history is impotent in face of the mystery

⁴⁶ Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, pp. 69–71 (21st September 1915).

⁴⁷ On Nietzsche’s attitude to the state, see: Mark Warner, *Nietzsche and Political Thought*, Cambridge, Mass. 1988, pp. 22–24, 219–223.

⁴⁸ Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, p. 77 (15th November 1915).

⁴⁹ Scholem, *Lamentations of Youth*, pp. 145–6.

of Jewish existence; science cannot decipher the Bible. Out of all the works one can think of, Scholem chose Nietzsche's early essays, *Untimely Meditations* (not the works generally considered most important), as ideal models of praise of the Bible – a clear sign of Scholem's respectful attitude to Nietzsche.

As we know that many of Scholem's pithy statements in his diary were of Nietzschean derivation, and as we know that *Zarathustra* inspired him, the historian Steve Aschheim comments: "We may regard his later statements as at best disingenuous"⁵⁰ Here one can offer an explanation: Scholem was not exceptional in distancing himself later on from Nietzsche, who had been a source of inspiration for him in his youth, as he was for many Jewish thinkers in Europe at an early stage of their intellectual development. Nietzsche was not regarded as just another thinker one could boast of. Dependence on him as a source of inspiration automatically identified the person influenced with the one who influenced, which was something inadvisable at a certain period in the case of a thinker considered one of the progenitors of the Nazis. Here one should remember that Nietzsche called for morality to be turned on its head, that he despised all liberal norms and humanist values and founded a new philosophy of will to power. All this did not help his reputation, especially during and after the Second World War, and people of mature years, whose outlook was already formed, chose to deny him as a thinker who inspired them when they were molding their personality. It is natural that creators who achieve greatness wish to kick away the ladder they climbed up.

In Search of Myth

The phenomenology of Jewish myth, Scholem's main preoccupation after the First World War, was suited to the European and Jewish intellectual climate of opinion in the period between the two World Wars. Scholem belonged to the current of European thought that searched for the mythical roots of modern man, which included Rudolf Otto and Mircea Eliade in the general sphere, and Franz Rozenzweig and Martin Buber in the Jewish sphere.

Like the German intellectuals Julius Langbehn, Paul de Lagarde and Moeller van den Bruck, Scholem discerned a politics of cultural despair in Germany, and like the agents of the conservative revolution Martin Heidegger, Carl Schmitt and Ernst Jünger, he identified the nihilism at the heart of the German consciousness.⁵¹ Unlike them, however, he envisaged a Promethean horizon beyond the boundaries of the Rhine: the possibility of founding a cultural community in Palestine, where he would help to give birth to a new Jewish civilization. The philosophical critique of the Enlightenment and the criticism of the German ideology influenced one another and were interconnected: "In the manner of Nietzsche, he saw these two enemies as one."⁵² Like Freud and Kafka, for example, Scholem took part in the post-Nietzschean criticism of the Enlightenment and reason, and like them he wanted to reveal the hidden dimensions of the human soul, and especially that of the Jew, which had been hidden beneath a rational conceptual cover until it had almost disappeared. This

⁵⁰ Steven Ashheim, Scholem, Arendt, Klemperer. *Intimate Chronicles in Turbulent Times*, Bloomington 2001, pp. 14–15, 102–103; Aschheim, *The Metaphysical Psychologist*, p. 906.

⁵¹ Fritz Stern, *The politics of Cultural Despair*, Berkeley 1961; Jeffrey Herf, *Reactionary Modernism: Technology, Culture and Politics in Weimar and the Third Reich*, Cambridge 1984.

⁵² Pachter, *Masters of Cultural History*, p. 22.

cultural and political intellectual atmosphere molded the young Scholem, influenced his decision to study the foundations of Jewish mysticism and found expression in his Jewish historiographical enterprise.

The romantic nationalism in Europe took hold of many young people whose search for their roots harmonized with their revolt against abstract rationalism. The cult of national renewal and the longing for a revival of myth was not only typical of young Jews. Herder was the one who flung open the doors of modern nationalism, and the German romantics after him searched for their national roots and participated in the national revival in the nineteenth century.⁵³ Scholem, a disciple of the German *Bildung*, belonged to the romantic national movement of the beginning of the twentieth century, and it swept him onto the shores of Jewish national historiography.⁵⁴ What the German national awakening and the Jewish national renaissance had in common was the attempt to locate in the culture of the past bodies of symbolism, religious rituals and sacred texts that would give lasting significance and authenticity to modern romanticism.

For Scholem, the history of religion was first and foremost symbology, a matter that was the common interest of the Eranos circle – a circle of leading historians of religion of which Scholem was a member, and which gathered under the inspiration of Carl Gustav Jung in Ascona in Switzerland from the end of the nineteen-forties until 1976.⁵⁵ This group gave itself the mission of investigating the phenomenology of religious symbols. Scholem claimed that the living God speaks in symbols, and that “Judaism was more than anything else a *corpus symbolicum*”.⁵⁶ The symbol is the mechanism that activates religious experience as well as national consciousness. It is not surprising that one of the main symbols that Scholem investigated was the star of David, and he traced the genealogy of its progress in the Middle Ages, in Sabbataeanism, in the Haskalah and in Zionism. The symbol, whose origin was medieval, was not originally Jewish but was a traditional talisman against the powers of evil, and it gained a Jewish significance only in the nineteenth century.⁵⁷ From the Haskalah and the Zionist movement to the Nazi regime this magic symbol was adopted in Europe as representative of the Jewish people. The Nazis gave the star of David a yellow color, which symbolized the return of the Jews to a state of degradation and finally extermination. Some claim that in Scholem’s genealogical investigation he humanized the symbol of the Jewish people, so taking it out of the hands of its conservative guardians and making it into a universal symbol. This symbol represented even the Reform Jews who are known for their desire to obliterate any mystical or magical element in modern Judaism. And there are some who criticize Scholem for claiming that the extermination of the European Jews is what gave the symbol a mythical significance. Like many Germans, he gave the Second World War and the

53 Zeev Sternhell, *The Anti-Enlightenment Tradition*, trans. by David Maisel, New Haven 2010, pp. 78–92, 115–128, 141–158, 247–278.

54 George Mosse, *Gershom Scholem as a German Jew*, in: George Mosse, *Confronting the Nation: Jewish and Western Nationalism*, Hanover / London 1993, pp. 176–192.

55 Steven M. Wasserstrom, *Religion After Religion: Gershom Scholem, Mircea Eliade, and Henry Corbin at Eranos*, New Jersey 1999, p. 217.

56 Wasserstrom, *Religion After Religion*, p. 217.

57 Gershom Scholem, *Das Davidschild. Geschichte eines Symbols*, Berlin 2010; Gershom Scholem, *The Star of David: History of a Symbol*, in: Gershom Scholem, *The Messianic Idea in Judaism and Other Essays on Jewish Spirituality*, New York 1971, pp. 257–281.

history of modern Europe an apocalyptic interpretation as a mythical event. It may be that he himself contributed to the connection of nationalism with mysticism.⁵⁸

Already in his first work, Scholem asserted that the connection between nationhood and mysticism is not only a fortuitous, technical or historical one but represents a deep existential affinity. Henry Pachter thought that this was a Copernican turning-point in historiography. Until Scholem, it was believed that mysticism had various cultural branches, but Scholem showed that Jewish mysticism, which was not influenced by its environment apart from technical influences, did not conform to this idea. Only a people which had experienced the suffering and shock of the Spanish exile could have developed the myth of God Himself living in exile and holding back the goodness of the world, a world in which evil held sway. Only such a people could suppose that God gives a message of total liberation from captivity, a special message to the Jewish people. The mythical significance of the Kabbala was particular, a significance that applied solely to the Jewish people and could not be understood by others. To such a degree was it impossible to untie the Gordian knot between the national aspect and the mystical aspect.⁵⁹ Robert Alter, however, proposed another, universal explanation. Although at the heart of the Kabbala, especially the Kabbala of Yitzhak Luria, there is a strong element of national rebirth, at the same time there is a pronounced universal aspect expressed in the formulation of an all-embracing cosmological doctrine. This understanding of the Kabbala gives us a new view of the rise of modern Jewish nationalism: Zionism can be seen as an attempt to renew the Jewish people in a universal perspective.⁶⁰ According to the model of the Lurian Kabbala, the revival of the Jewish State can strengthen the universal nature of Jewish nationhood and not turn the nation into an isolated island in the Middle East.

So, does the Kabbala belong to the Jewish national heritage or to the universal religious tradition? Scholem believed that a myth and a people are close to each other: a nation cannot forgo any part of its past.⁶¹ The Reform Jews who wanted to have a rational religion and to assimilate into the Western Enlightenment were bewildered by mystical and magical elements and ideas connected to the Kabbala, and that was the reason for their attempt to obliterate the memory of kabbalistic texts. Scholem said that although the practices of the Kabbala could not be revived, their memory could be. The historical chapter of the Kabbala had to be reconnected to the other chapters in the history of the Jewish people. The revival of the Kabbala was not only a matter of historiographical importance but a matter of national importance. Scholem looked for a myth that would support the miracle of the renewal of Jewish culture. Myths become pragmatic as soon as they are given a role within the continuity of history, and that, in fact, is what Nietzsche and Scholem intended.⁶² The myth of the Kabbala was intended for a Messianic mobilization, and here Scholem was a good example of the history-myth dialectic. Myth lies outside the historical consciousness, but at the same time it operates in history and molds it. The myths taken from history – the Bar Kochba rebellion, the expulsion from Spain or the Messiahship of Shabbetai Zvi – became a-historical

⁵⁸ Yosef Schwartz, Paper Tiger, in: Haaretz, 21 April 2009 [Hebrew].

⁵⁹ Pachter, *Masters of Cultural History*, p. 16.

⁶⁰ Alter, *The Achievement of Gershom Scholem*, p. 76.

⁶¹ Pachter, *Masters of Cultural History*, p. 17; Gershom Scholem, *Kabbalah and Myth. On the Kabbalah and Its Symbolism*, trans. by Ralph Manheim, New York 1969.

⁶² David Ohana, J. L. Talmon, Gershom Scholem and the Price of Messianism, in: *History of European Ideas* 34.2 (June 2008), pp. 169–188.

myths because they were detached from their time and nourished the historical memory. The reconstruction of history provided examples of how to change the present moment. Scholem traced the inner logic of the rise and fall of myths in Jewish culture in order to accelerate the progress of Jewish history in his time. In this he did not make a rationalization of history but rebelled against the idea that reason is the main factor that molds, or ought to mold, reality.

At the beginning of the modern age when the ghettoized Jewish world of eastern and central Europe began to undergo a process of modernization, many Jewish groups sincerely believed that a new age was at hand. They had the feeling that they saw the beginning of Messianic redemption. The heavenly city was about to become a permanent reality; the contradiction between the Messianic vision and the vale of tears was about to be effaced; the dream would become true. To those who believed this, said Scholem, “the presence of a Messianic reality seemed entirely in harmony with the outward course of events.”⁶³ The researches of the anthropologist Bronislaw Malinowski and his successors seem to support Scholem’s assertions by showing that myth in primitive societies is not a product of the artistic imagination or an intellectual explanation but a reality of life.⁶⁴ Primitive communities do not experience life in a simultaneous way – reality and vision, history and utopia. This way of seeing requires a critical faculty that only develops with the processes of secularization and modernization.

In the seventeenth century, a synthesis became possible between the traditional Messianic idea and the kabbalistic vision with the appearance of the Lurian Kabbala which prepared the intellectual climate in which Sabbetai Sevi sprang up. A transformation took place in the concept of national liberation, which changed its meaning from release from foreign rule to an all-embracing Messianic cosmology. It was no longer a matter of changing of historical situation but a cosmological upheaval; no longer the aspiration to the independence of the Hebrew nation as the vanguard of a universal Messianic era but a cosmic redemption, the reparation of the ‘shattered’ universe and the restoration of the unified structure of the worlds. The kabbalists transformed the outward manifestations of redemption into symbols of a spiritual process. Ernst Cassirer has already taught us that man is a landscape of symbols. The philosopher of symbolic forms claimed that man lives in a dimension that is not only the natural world but also the world of symbols. Language, art, religion, science and myth are the complex threads of the human enterprise which is a network of coordinates by means of which we make our way in the world.⁶⁵

The study of Kabbala meant for Scholem first and foremost turning his back on the abstract philosophy of the middle class and a rejection of the rational man it created – a golem of bourgeois culture. Like Marx and Freud who in their different ways sought to restore humanism to the alienated technological modern era, Scholem used his kabbalistic insights for the same purpose. He knew that man as *homo mythicus* could not satisfy his intellect by means of the idealistic philosophy. Because Jewish philosophy did not provide answers to the anxieties concerning life and death, it had to pay a high price for its estrangement from the primitive foundations of man’s life. Jewish thinkers preferred to see evil and the demonic as problems to be thrust aside, not as problems from which myths are created. The same way of thinking made Scholem reveal the sexual and feminine sides of God. He devoted all

⁶³ Scholem, *Redemption Through Sin*, p. 87.

⁶⁴ Bronislaw Malinowski, *Magic, Science, Religion and Other Essays*, Boston 1948; Bronislaw Malinowski, *Myth in Primitive Psychology*, London 1926.

⁶⁵ Ernst Cassirer, *Symbol, Myth and Culture*, New Haven 1979.

his time and energy to the study of Jewish symbolism, and the results of his investigations shook the foundations of rabbinic Judaism just as Freud shocked Victorian society with his discoveries.⁶⁶

Unlike prophetic Judaism, in which the godhead is an entity without characteristics who is represented in the Bible in an allegorical way like the commandments in the works of an Aristotelian philosopher like Maimonides, Jewish mysticism gave the godhead a mythological life and a symbolic significance. The kabbalists, who brought back the pagan principles of magical religions, said that theosophy and myth bridged the enormous gap between the abstract deity and his symbolic representations. The mystical movements which flourished along the Rhine and in Provence particularly in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries appear to have been influenced by the gnostics. Whereas the researches of Hans Jonas abound in kabbalist-gnostic parallels, Scholem tried to play them down.⁶⁷ In both systems, the gnostic and the kabbalist, knowledge liberates and deepens the sphere of consciousness. The gnostics believed that there are sparks hidden in the world which need to be liberated so that the creation can be united with the godhead. In addition to the overlapping of the gnostic concept of alienation and the kabbalistic concept of exile, there is also a great similarity between the Lurian cosmology and the gnostic view of the creation.

Some of Scholem's commentators see Nietzsche's *The Birth of Tragedy* as the historiographical model chosen by the Jewish scholar.⁶⁸ Just as the German philosopher found in early Greece the model of inspiration for the creation of a myth for the German people, so Scholem went back to the Middle Ages and the beginning of modern times in order to create a national myth for the modern Jews. In his lectures at the Leo Baeck Institute in New York in 1959, Scholem said that he envied the German historians who yearned for a comprehensive and active understanding of their historical organism in a national perspective and futuristic orientation. A commitment of this kind is often found in historiography when historians decide to be creators of myths of their nation. They do not boast of setting up a universalist intellectual republic whose cosmopolitan language would transcend national frontiers. The idea that universal ideas can be realized by national means has died out.⁶⁹ Henceforth, the truth is fragmented: there is a Jewish truth, a Nazi truth, imperialist and liberal truths, and so on. Pachter warns against a dangerous viewpoint of this kind, especially when expressed by Jews living in Israel. That, precisely, is the trouble: this distortion of historiography is liable to gain acceptance among the *modern* or the *engagés* in the form of a counter-culture or as in the Frankfurt school.⁷⁰

Modern society deprives people of their individuality and neglects the virtues of the traditional community and the natural relationships of family and friends. Liberal society leaves people 'soulless', and the results of the Enlightenment can be described as what Georg Simmel called modern man's 'estrangement' from his roots. One can understand in this context the myth of the expulsion from Eden and the legend of the wandering Jew.⁷¹ At the beginning of the twentieth century, the call to return to the life of the community was

⁶⁶ Pachter, *Masters of Cultural History*, p. 23.

⁶⁷ Hans Jonas, *Gnosticism and Modern Nihilism*, in: *Social Research* (December 1952), pp. 430–452.

⁶⁸ David Biale, *Gershom Scholem: Kabbalah and Counter-History*, Cambridge, Mass. 1979, p. 35.

⁶⁹ Ernst Cassirer, *The Myth of the State*, New Haven 1946.

⁷⁰ On the affinity to Nietzsche of the Frankfurt school, see Martin Jay, *The Dialectical Imagination: A History of the Frankfurt School and the Institute of Social Research, 1923–1950*, Boston 1973.

⁷¹ Pachter, *Masters of Cultural History*, p. 19.

heard once again. Romantic nationalism which expressed a sense of community challenged the liberal, universalist and rationalist tendencies of the time. A consequence of this was that one could point to the 'other', the enemy, the source of alienation – the Jew. It is thus ironic that while the antisemites blamed the Jewish domination for the loss of their souls, Scholem declared that it was rather the Jews who had lost their uniqueness by yielding to the domination of the Germans. As long as the nationalism at the beginning of the twentieth century was a cultural rebellion against the liberal world of his father, Scholem could allow himself to be open to the German and Jewish currents of his generation, but as a Jew reared and educated in Wilhelmine Germany he was unable to join the national romantics of his time. His protest took the form of anti-German feelings and a hankering after Jewish tradition. These circumstances and the direction of his thought were interactive, and the concepts that henceforth dominated his researches were exile and redemption. The exposure of Jewish nationalism in Palestine as a strain of German nationalism which sought as a secular movement to solve a spiritual problem by secular means, and the arrogance of seeking to rescue the Jews at the expense of the rescue of Judaism, caused Scholem to leave political Zionism. He settled in Palestine in 1923 not in order to set up a State but to revive a cultural community which had theological roots and to re-establish its Jewish essence.

In contrast to the Promethean passion of secular Zionism to give birth to the "new Hebrew" in his country, Scholem at the outset of his career tended towards the mystical nationalism cultivated by the German youth movements and the first pioneering waves of immigration, a romantic nationalism in the spirit of Buber or Tolstoy. In Palestine he wished to find redemption from the German exile.

Scholem found in Walter Benjamin and Ernst Bloch and among the thinkers of the Frankfurt school the Jewish roots of utopian thought, a way of thinking common both to him and to them.⁷² Scholem rejected the Marxist starting-point and its conclusion that Messianic movements are social ones.⁷³ He believed, on the contrary, that the Messianic myth was primarily religious. He saw Ernst Bloch's book on Thomas Müntzer,⁷⁴ for example, as an expressionistic manifestation of Karl Kautsky's Marxist essays.⁷⁵ Rejecting the neo-Kantian view of myth as pre-scientific thinking, Bloch holds that it is the very core of a symbolic culture. If in 1918 Bloch believed that myth could offer hope for the future, by 1935 he had come to understand its destructive potential, like Ernst Cassirer, who in 1924 wrote about the swastika in a neutral vein. Bloch believed in the transcendent quality of myth: symbolic culture is born of an unsatisfied hunger, a state of depression, which seeks to break out of its limitations. Secularization merely made possible the context in which myth gained ascendancy, the possibility of a renewed experience of the essence that bygone ages had given to myth: "the savior still lives and will return." Walter Benjamin, too, was bent on saving myth – by means of allegory. In addition to the criticism of the Enlightenment and the criticism of the bourgeois ideology, a Messianic approach was common to Scholem, Bloch, Benjamin and the Frankfurt school as a basic pattern of their thinking.

⁷² Jay, *The Dialectical Imagination*, pp. 198–202.

⁷³ Ernst Bloch, *Heritage of Our Times*, Berkeley 1991.

⁷⁴ Ernst Bloch, *Thomas Münzer als Theologe der Revolution*, Frankfurt am Main 1960.

⁷⁵ Gershom Scholem, *Wohnt Gott im Herzen eines Atheisten? Zu Ernst Blochs 90. Geburtstag*, in: *Der Spiegel*, 7. 7. 1975, pp. 110–114.

Messianism Through Nihilism

The Sabbatean theology recognized a special class of “spiritualists”, exceptional individuals, men of spiritual elevation who succeeded in penetrating a world that was all holiness and spirit. These men of elevation, like Nietzsche’s *Übermensch*, had qualities not given to the generality of mankind. They usually lived as a sect in an enclosed space, a spiritual *heterotopia*, to use Michel Foucault’s expression, and kept a distance from a normative way of life.⁷⁶ One should remember that a sect is different from an order. A sect is a group of people that isolates itself from normative society in order to pursue a closed lifestyle, while an order is an organization of people who set themselves up as an ideal example of a counter-culture, an ideal microcosm of a perfect society, and in Scholem’s words, to paraphrase, they claimed to be the vanguard of a new world. Scholem pointed out that after the Second Temple period, Jewish tradition did not encourage the phenomenon of “spiritualists”, some of whom went over to Christianity. In hassidism, for instance, there were men of spiritual pretension who considered themselves superior beings, but the regulatory mechanisms of the hassidic community prevented their descent into nihilism. Hassidism, like Sabbetaianism, rejected the external world, but, unlike it, stopped short on the edge of the abyss.

While moderate Sabbetaianism was careful not to cross the threshold into nihilism, extreme Sabbetaianism declared: “Let us cram the maw of impurity with the power of holiness until it bursts from within.”⁷⁷ The word *tehom* (chasm or abyss) recurs in Scholem’s essay, and it was the key word in the nihilistic theology of the radical Sabbetaians. “The philosophy of the chasm”, if one can call it that, was in Scholem’s words, “the spiritual platform for the outbreak of the great nihilistic conflagration in extreme Sabbetaianism.” Here several factors coalesced – religious beliefs, spiritual tendencies and anarchistic impulses – and together lit the Sabbetaian fire. The revolutionary euphoria and sense of freedom, now that all impediments had been removed and all partitions had collapsed, removed the few restrictions of the Jewish norms that still remained.⁷⁸

Sabbetai Sevi and Jacob Frank, unlike Bar Kochba, did not go forth to war. As soon as it transpired, said Scholem, that, as a result of the chasm between the external world and the inner reality, the objective reality had to be denied, Messianism was transformed into nihilism. The paradoxical rationale of the Sabbetaian believer – the Marrano basis as the psychological explanation of Sabbetaianism – contradicted the principle that his inside was as his outside. The contrary was true: the outward belief was the opposite of the inner belief. Everything was upside-down: the outward act was not genuine and the genuine article was hidden and duplicitous towards the world: the sacred became profane, and the profane sacred. To express this, the Sabbetaians made their own use of the talmudic saying, “The violation of the Torah is now its true fulfilment.”⁷⁹ With their sense of paradox and their insistence that ‘the contrary is true’, they delighted in proclaiming the sanctity of sin, a known phenomenon in the history of religious sects. In radical Sabbetaianism one again finds the psychological affinity between an extreme intellectual climate and the growth of nihilistic theories.

⁷⁶ Michel Foucault, *Les mots et les choses*, Paris 1966.

⁷⁷ Scholem, *Redemption Through Sin*, p. 109.

⁷⁸ Ohana, *Introduction to: The Dawn of Political Nihilism*, Brighton and Portland 2012, pp. 1–12.

⁷⁹ Scholem, *Redemption Through Sin*, p. 109.

Nietzsche called for a transvaluation of values in life and in history, and a change in the relationship between them. The transvaluation of all values included his division of history into the categories of monumental, antiquarian and critical. Each was needed in an equal measure, and each in its proper proportion. In monumental history Nietzsche put supra-historical figures of outstanding intelligence who enhance life and are like torches on mountain-tops. Scholem had no particular liking for monumental history, and in a spirit of negation focused on the failed messianism of the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries that placed its trust in 'myth-leaders'. In modern Jewish nationalism – Zionism – there were two major Jewish leaders who according to Scholem embodied the messianic idea in their personalities: Rabbi Abraham Kook, the first chief Rabbi of Palestine and David Ben-Gurion. Both were responsible – each in his time and in his own sphere – for shifting Messianism from the domain of the future and the ideal towards an eventual nationalization of the messianic idea. In that context, Scholem was afraid that radical branches of Zionism – as he later warned about the fundamentalist group of 'Gush Emunim' – shall become modern Sabbetaianism.

The Sabbatian radicalization appeared in the form of the Frankist movement in the 18th century. The 'Frankist syndrome' was outstanding in its dual character: the sanctification of destruction plus a hymn of praise to militarism. Their juxtaposition created a nihilist antinomianism on the one hand and iron discipline and military order on the other, not as opposites but as the two sides of the Frankist coin. The new type of Jew envisaged by the Frankists was no longer a teacher and expositor but a fighter and military man. The renewal of the Jewish people, they believed, would not take place within the walls of the house of study but on the battlefield, for the Jews, the descendants of David, ought not to learn Torah but the use of arms: in the near future, said Frank, every six-year old child will be trained in the tactics of war, and in this way we will get an army of ten million men chosen from among the Jews, and thus the children of Israel will become an army.⁸⁰ The conquest of this world requires one to learn the art of war and military strategy, not in an allegorical sense but as an urgent personal need. The aim was to create an armed, belligerent, productive and independent community that would rule through its own resources over a defined geographical area. Frank called to take up arms and preserve an iron military discipline, looking neither right nor left. Here nihilistic and militaristic elements could no longer be separated. Frankist Sabbetaianism brought Sabbetaian nihilism to such a pitch of perfection that it canceled itself out. The conclusion to be drawn from this is that the existing system of laws has to be repealed. It was for this purpose that Moses, Jesus and Sabbetai Sevi were sent into the world. As even they did not succeed, only one effective path remained: the path of nihilism.⁸¹ Life would be restored to its plenitude by the annulment of all laws and religions and by following the leader to the end.

It is interesting to compare the views of Nietzsche and Scholem (or his anti-hero, Frank) on nihilism. Here we have to make a methodological observation and say that with the appearance of Nietzsche, as Albert Camus put it, "Nihilism becomes conscious for the first time [...]. He recognized nihilism for what it was and examined it like a clinical fact."⁸² Opposite Nietzsche, the dissector of modern nihilism, stands Frank, the leader of a sect

⁸⁰ Scholem, *The Sabbatian Movement in Poland*, pp. 68–140.

⁸¹ Scholem, *Redemption Through Sin*, p. 130.

⁸² Albert Camus, *The Rebel*, New York 1956, pp. 65–66. See also: Geoffrey S. Kirk (ed.), *The Cosmic Fragments*, New York 1962; Jean Granier, *Le Problème de la vérité dans la philosophie de Nietzsche*, Paris 1966, pp. 190–200.

who preached a religious nihilism, not an expositor but a subverter who went to the limit. Scholem described the mystical nihilism and disharmonious universe of Jacob Frank's school of thought:

Utterly free, fettered by no law or authority, this 'Life' never ceases to produce forms and to destroy what it has produced. It is the anarchic promiscuity of all living things. Into this bubbling cauldron, this continuum of destruction, the mystic plunges. To him it is the ultimate human experience. For Frank, anarchic destruction represented all the Luciferian radiance, all the positive tones and overtones, of the word 'Life.' The nihilistic mystic descends into the abyss in which the freedom of living things is born; he passes through all the embodiments and forms that come his way, committing himself to none; and not content with rejecting and abrogating all values and laws, he tramples them underfoot and desecrates them, in order to attain the exilir of Life.⁸³

And as in the Frankist universe so well described by Scholem, in the Nietzschean universe there is infinite negativity without structure and consequently without stability, purpose, truth, value, or any other meaning:

And do you know what "the world" is to me? Shall I show it to you in my mirror? This world; a monster of energy, without beginning, without end; a firm, iron magnitude of force that does not grow bigger or smaller, that does not expend itself but only transforms itself; as a whole, of unalterable size, a household without expenses or losses, but likewise without increase or income; enclosed by "nothingness" as by a boundary; not something blurry or wasted, not something endlessly extended, but set in a definite space as a definite force, and not a space that might be "empty" here or there, but rather a force throughout, as a play of forces and waves of forces, at the same time one and many, increasing here and at the same time decreasing there; a sea of forces flowing and rushing together, eternally changing, eternally flooding back, with tremendous years of recurrence, with an ebb and a flow of its forms; out of the simplest forms striving toward the most complex, out of the stillest, most rigid, coldest forms toward the hottest, most turbulent, most self-contradictory, and then again returning home to the simple out of this abundance, out of the play of contradictions back to the joy of concord [...].⁸⁴

Scholem, like Benjamin (and following Nietzsche) looked at many narratives in Judaism and chose those that went against the grain. The significance of the episodes of Sabbetai Sevi and Frank was contrary to the meta-narrative of rabbinical Judaism, which represented the 'formal' Jewish religion.

In the period between the two World Wars, the outstanding figures in the study of the history of religions were Rudolf Otto and Gerardus van der Leew among the older historians and Mircea Eliade and Henry Corbin among the younger ones. According to Steven Wasserstrom, author of *Religion After Religion*, the works of these scholars were characterized by a Nietzschean scheme of reference, the investigation of extreme religious phenomena and a comprehensive approach to their subject.⁸⁵ Scholem, who already had the reputation of being the most eminent scholar of Judaism in the twentieth century, belonged to this tradi-

⁸³ Scholem, *Religious Authority and Mysticism*, pp. 28–29.

⁸⁴ Nachlass 1885, 38[12], KSA 11.610f., quoted from WP §1067, transl. Walter Kaufmann und R. J. Hollingdale.

⁸⁵ Wasserstrom, *Religion After Religion*, p. 216.

tion. His lectures in Ascona (where the Eranos Circle met), like *Religious Authority and Mysticism* (1957) and “Nihilism as a Religious Phenomenon” (1974) were not intended as Jewish dissertations but as studies in the general history of religion.

When Scholem visited Paris in 1927, four years after he immigrated to Palestine, Scholem met Walter Benjamin. In his book *The Story of a Friendship*, Scholem wrote: “Benjamin was the first person I told about a very surprising discovery I had made: Sabbetaian theology – that is, a Messianic antinomianism that had developed within Judaism in strictly Jewish concepts.”⁸⁶ The two friends discussed the burning question, “What in fact is Judaism?” Was Judaism still a heritage, or was it an experience, or an object of scientific investigation? Scholem aimed at that time at achieving a comprehensive science and total theory of religion, and in this connection it is an interesting fact that in 1931 Benjamin searched in Paris for a certain book on Sabbetai Sevi that Scholem had asked for. The historian Jeffrey Mehlman suggests that the subject of ‘false Messiahs’ had come up at their meeting in Paris, a meeting that became a turning-point in Scholem’s investigations.⁸⁷ Are we to infer from this that the thesis of “Redemption Through Sin” came out of the intellectual climate between the two world wars and not out of the libraries of Mount Scopus in Jerusalem?

In a study-day devoted to a discussion of norms and values, Scholem chose to speak of the reversal of values and their devaluation to the point where they disappeared. In his article “Nihilism As a Religious Phenomenon” published in 1974, based on lecture he gave to the Eranos Circle, he claimed that nihilism was umbilically connected to Nietzsche:

Ever since Nietzsche, in his *Will to Power*, called for nihilism, the most mysterious guest to knock on our doors, this guest has sat on our table, and instead of being removed, he rules over us!⁸⁸

In “Nihilism As a Religious Phenomenon”, Scholem made a comprehensive survey of nihilism and drew up its genealogy. Nihilism, in his opinion, was a term that changed its meaning in different historical and philosophical contexts. In the immediate post-war years Scholem changed his concept of nihilism from a political theology that favored destruction, a position that was widespread in the German intellectual climate in the period between the two World Wars (it was shared by Carl Schmitt and to some degree by Walter Benjamin), to a more moderate concept, “quiet nihilism.” This could be understood as a nihilism of an anarchical kind. The first sign of nihilism’s retreat from the political field was in a discussion that Scholem had with his brother Werner in 1914, a time when the concept signified his opposition to the war as against the social democrats who supported it. The meaning of nihilism at that time was abstaining from involvement in politics and a search for a new political idea. Unlike Benjamin, Scholem looked for a new dimension in which abstract nihilism could find a political anchor, and he found it in the context of Zionism.

When he reached Palestine, Scholem abandoned his preoccupation with the Messianic aspect of the war and the revolution in Europe in favor of the study of Kabbala and involvement in the new problems presented by the Middle East. In the initial years of his immigra-

⁸⁶ Gershom Scholem, Walter Benjamin. *The Story of a Friendship*, trans. by Harry Zohn, New York 2000, p. 136.

⁸⁷ Jeffrey Mehlman, *Walter Benjamin for Children*, Chicago 1993.

⁸⁸ Vgl. Scholem, *Der Nihilismus als religiöses Phänomen*. For additional explanation on that paragraph, see: Eric Jacobson, *Metaphysics of the Profane. The Political Theology of Walter Benjamin and Gershom Scholem*, New York 2003, p. 69.

tion, there was a change in his understanding of the terms ‘anarchism’ and ‘nihilism’, and he gave them a new meaning. One should remember that in Europe, the starting-point was a distinction between ‘anarchism’ and ‘nihilism’. Anarchism, as seen by its founders, was a search for a harmonious world whose peace had been shattered by a handful of corrupt politicians and capitalists. Propaganda through action – that is, terror exercised by a minority that seized control of power and property – would restore the original order. Nihilism was quite the opposite. According to this concept, the world had been broken up and disharmonious from the beginning, a sort of orderless order, and one had continually to work to keep it that way.

The change that took place in the Zionist context, expressed in Scholem’s article “Redemption Through Sin”, was that these concepts now became violent and self-destructive forces, energies that gave rise to an apocalyptic Messianism infinitely far removed from the secular universalist Messianism associated with the idea of progress of the Enlightenment. Destruction-for-destruction’s-sake was seen in Sabbetaian Messianism as the explanation for the apostasy of Sabbetai Sevi and his followers. In “Nihilism as a Religious Phenomenon”, Scholem portrayed the nihilist in a different way from that he had done previously. The nihilist was now seen as a Russian revolutionary: “a permanent opponent of any kind of authority, who cannot accept principles or beliefs unconnected with the intention underlying the principles.”⁸⁹ The nihilist was now a modern rebel who rejected the contradictions of Russian feudal and pre-capitalist life and consequently became a self-creator beyond social norms.

Nihilism, said Scholem in 1974 in reference to Nietzsche, waits at the doors of bourgeois society, ready to expose hypocrisy. “The anarchists,” he continued, “actively incorporated this idea [nihilism] in their propaganda and were the classic representatives of nihilism in the eyes of other groups. Before Nietzsche – far beyond the limits of politics and related to the collapse of authoritarian value-systems – nihilism was known as a guest waiting to enter our celebration.”⁹⁰ Nietzsche explained the appearance of nihilism by the internal logic of European history until that time, by the cultural development of Europe with its Christian morality.⁹¹

According to Scholem, the change in the concept of nihilism from a secular revolt to a political theology was in keeping with the shift of philosophical nihilistic movements towards action: The decline of old authoritarian and religious value-systems still based on revelation was considered a result of the collapse of the religious universe connected with critical philosophical movements which were nihilistic. The ‘quiet nihilism’ Scholem referred to distinguishing it from the ‘nihilism of action’ implies that “institutions and reality itself must be negated or destroyed not through active opposition but through reflection and metaphysical means.”⁹² One can see that “quiet nihilism” is non-involvement in this-worldly matters, while the other nihilism is a “nihilism of action,” a part of an active and radical historical movement which can revolutionize the world. Its guiding principle is that transgressing the Torah is truly to reveal it (“the annulment of the Torah is its observance”). This nihilism according to Scholem was the essence of the Sabbetaian dialectic. Hans Jonas, Leo

⁸⁹ Scholem, *Judaica*, Frankfurt 1992, vol. V. pp. 122–124 (my transl.).

⁹⁰ Scholem, *Judaica*, vol. IV, p. 130.

⁹¹ Karl Löwith, *The Historical Background of European Nihilism*, in: Karl Löwith, *Nature, History and Existentialism*, Northwestern 1966, pp. 3–16.

⁹² Jacobson, *The Metaphysics of the Profane*, p. 131.

Strauss and Hans Blumenberg, who belonged to the same philosophical school as Scholem and whose thinking also reflected a confrontation with Nietzschean nihilism, disapproved of Scholem's Frankist model and his "Nietzschean moods."⁹³

Nihilism, as philosophical scepticism, as a religious phenomenon and as a political message, attracted the young Scholem. In 1937, the year he wrote his "nihilistic" article "Redemption Through Sin", Scholem mentioned in a letter to Zalman Schocken his desire "to proceed on the fine line between religion and nihilism."⁹⁴ But he had no intention of falling into the abyss like Frank, the chief character of his essay, for he knew that nihilism was not only a form of dissatisfaction with the world, but its ultimate aim was to destroy it. Two of his acquaintances sought to warn him against this phenomenon: Leo Strauss warned him against the possibility of "identifying nihilism with philosophy"⁹⁵ and the Israeli culture critic Baruch Kurzweil pointed out the dangers of dabbling in demonology and the temptations of nihilism.⁹⁶ Nihilism, for both Nietzsche and Scholem, was an immanent position, a sort of permanent parting of the ways where a man could break his limbs, fall into total nothingness, suicide, scepticism and degeneracy, but, beyond this, he can function once more and effect a transvaluation of values.

In 1975, a year after the publication of "Nihilism As a Religious Phenomenon", a correspondence began between Gershom Scholem and Ernst Jünger in connection with Werner Scholem, Gershom's communist brother, who went to school with Jünger.⁹⁷ The First World War was a parting of the ways for Gershom Scholem and Ernst Jünger. The former was a pacifistic Jewish youth taking his first steps in Germany in the fields of Judaism and Zionism who was eventually to become one of the greatest scholars of Judaism in the twentieth century, and the latter was a German romantic, two years older than Scholem, who sought a life of danger and adventure, welcomed the war, and eventually became one of the leading modern German writers. Nietzsche's works exerted their magnetism on both these young people. While Scholem wanted to be "the Zarathustra of the Jews", Jünger sought Zarathustra in the trenches and succeeded in dragging him there. Scholem foresaw the horrors of the war which in his opinion represented the negative climax of modernity, and evaded service in the war of the German bourgeoisie on the pretext of mental illness; Jünger, enthusiastic about the existential and technical possibilities of the first total war, volunteered to serve, was wounded in battle and received the highest decoration for bravery. Scholem abandoned his German homeland and immigrated to Palestine with the intention of re-establishing Jewish sovereignty there, whereas Jünger was an officer of the Wehrmacht in the Nazi army of occupation in Paris. The matter of nihilism – inspired by Nietzsche, the modern philosopher of nihilism – was the main issue in the correspondence of these two thinkers.

Unlike many thinkers who betrayed Nietzsche when they took *Zarathustra* into the trenches, Jünger had a profound understanding of the Nietzschean *Lebensphilosophie* and

⁹³ Benjamin Lazier, *God Interrupted: Heresy and the European Imagination between the World Wars*, New Jersey 2012, p. 179.

⁹⁴ Lazier, *God Interrupted*, p. 180.

⁹⁵ Lazier, *God Interrupted*, p. 192.

⁹⁶ Baruch Kurzweil, Remarks on Gershom Scholem's Sabbatai Zevi, in: Baruch Kurzweil, *In the Struggle for Jewish Values*, Jerusalem 1969, pp. 99–134 [Hebrew].

⁹⁷ The correspondence between Gershom Scholem and Ernst Jünger, Gershom Scholem Archive, National Library, file 1599013034, 4*.

a deep love for the progenitor of the will to power.⁹⁸ When Jünger fused his interpretation of Nietzsche with his sense of the aesthetic attraction of the war and the experience of the trenches, he was no longer one more author writing about the war but had become its most enthusiastic advocate.

The Scholem brothers saw with disgust the German youth of their age running in their thousands to the “Nietzschean adventure”, as the first technological total war was called by one of its participants. Gershom Scholem said it was “mass-murder which is also called a cultural war.”⁹⁹ Werner refused his father’s demand that he should enlist in the war as a German patriot, but at the same time was not quick to break off contact with him. He finally did enlist in the army, and was severely wounded. When released, he participated in uniform in an anti-war demonstration and was consequently accused of betraying the fatherland. His father repudiated his two sons and threw them out of the house. In 1915 Gershom Scholem was expelled from his school after writing a letter condemning the war in which he claimed that the cult of war and Zionism were incompatible. At the same time, Werner the pacifist joined the social-democratic party, and he was later a member of the Communist Party, from which he was expelled in 1926. After frequent imprisonments in 1933, the year the Nazis came to power, Werner fell into the trap that awaited him and was murdered in Buchenwald on the 17th of July 1940.

⁹⁸ Erich Brock, *Das Weltbild Ernst Jüngers. Darstellung und Deutung*, Zürich 1945.

⁹⁹ On Scholem’s attitude to the First World War, see his autobiographical work *From Berlin to Jerusalem*.